



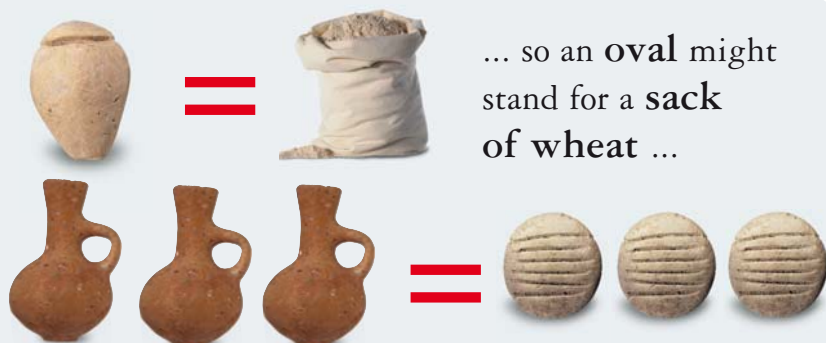
Making a *mark*

For hundreds of thousands of years, people managed fine by counting with their hands. But about 6000 years ago, the world changed. In the Middle East, people figured out how to tame animals and plant crops – they became farmers.



BABYLONIAN *numbers*

About 6000 years ago, the farmers in Babylonia (Iraq) started making clay tokens as records of deals. They had different-shaped tokens for different things ...



... so an **oval** might stand for a **sack of wheat** ...

... and a **circle** might mean a **jar of oil**. For two or three jars of oil, two or three tokens were exchanged.

When a deal involved several tokens, they were wrapped together in a clay envelope. To show what was inside, the trader made symbols on the outside with a pointed stick. Then someone had the bright idea of simply marking clay with symbols and not bothering with tokens at all. And that's how writing was invented.

